

BLOCK 4
REPORTING BEATS-2



UNIT 11 SPORTS REPORTING

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11.0 INTRODUCTION

Sport Accord, the association of most of the large international sports federations says that an activity to qualify as 'sport' should have an element of competition, be in no way damaging to a living creature, should not bank on an equipment provided by a single supplier (excluding proprietary games such as arena football) and should not rely on any "luck" element specifically designed into the sport. According to the Oxford English dictionary defines sports as, "...an activity involving physical exertion and skill in which an individual or team competes against another or others for entertainment."

Sports enhances our physical, mental, and spiritual health. It has the potential to unite and reconcile people of different colours, ethnicities, religions, and cultures. While ancient sports were primarily instinctive and recreational, modern sports are primarily competitive.

In the last few years, however, India has been working in many ways to build a strong sports environment and sports culture. Multiple groups are working to get kids and teens involved in sports and physical activities by making it easier for people from all socioeconomic backgrounds to play sports and get to them. People are setting up sports schools to meet the demand for good sports facilities and world-class coaching. Media also wants better policies for sports.

Today, there are a lot more people watching and playing sports than there were a few years ago. Along with this, we can see that there is more sports coverage in newspaper, TV, and the web. Also, a lot of movies and

commercials are being made about sports. Sports events are held on a regular basis. Sports agencies, academies, and manufacturing businesses all hire PROs. Because of all these changes, there are a lot of new trends and different kinds of news and stories about sports.

In this Unit, we will talk about how sports in India have changed over time and give a brief history of sports in India. We will also talk about the benefits of sports to society, the growing sports business, and, most importantly, how Indian media cover sports. We'll talk about how sports reporting is changing and find out what skills and traits a sports reporter needs.

11.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After going through this Unit, you will be able to:

- understand the expansion and growth of sports in India;
- describe the contemporary scenario of sports reporting in different media;
- explain the qualities and skills required in a good sports reporter; and
- discuss the emerging trends in sports reporting.

11.2 SPORTS IN INDIA

Cricket is one of the most popular games in India. Players, managers, and people who talk about the game on TV are treated like celebrities in the country, especially among young people. And cricket has been bigger than other games for a long time. Other games have also popularity. Now many professional leagues like the Hockey India League, Pro Kabaddi League, Indian Super League, Indian Wrestling League, Indian Badminton League, Indian Golf League, Indian Volleyball League and Indian Racing League have started. The feeling of loss has been wiped away by the medals won at the Commonwealth Games, Asian Games and Olympics. Cricket is a proof that wins and medal counts are what make a sport powerful and popular.

In order to win more medals at international competitions, policymakers are trying to in still sports ideals and a sports culture in the society. They do this by encouraging young people with skills and talent and by making sports a required part of the curriculum from elementary school to university. The government has added more money to its sports budget. This backs up the idea that India is quickly changing from a "sports-loving" or "sports-watching" country to a "sports-playing" country.

11.3 SPORTS REPORTING IN INDIAN MEDIA

The thrill of winning and the pain of losing, the drama of battle or the making of champions—sports reporting is the gathering, putting together, and sharing with the public of stories, events, issues, and happenings in the world of sports. A sports reporter has to cover, write about, and talk about a lot of different things. These include basic game-centered stories like turning points, big moments, and major glitches in sporting events, key decisions of captains and coaches, etc., as well as fights, controversies, legal and

investigative scoops, sensational things that happen in the lives of players, and many other bits of information that sports fans look forward to in a variety of stories.

With the growth of the sports business, there are now more people who have a stake in it. Local, regional, national, and foreign groups are putting on a lot of events and tournaments for different games. The government has realized how important sports are and is trying to get more people to start playing sports as early as grade school. Sports and sports laws are debated and talked about by people of all backgrounds and jobs. Several sports-focused TV and radio stations, newspapers, magazines, and websites have started to meet this need for sports news and fun.

In this part, we'll look at how sports are getting more coverage in India.

11.3.1 Growing Sports Coverage in India

In many places where people love sports and play them, sports journalism is just as important as other kinds of journalism. There are a lot of people who watch and read sports media. In the past, sports were called the "toy beat" or "non-serious department" to make fun of them, but that is no longer the case. There are now more sports pages in journals than there used to be. Media outlets have a sports desk and sports correspondents who go to all the big national and foreign sports events to report on them. Along with cricket, other sports are now being covered and written about in Indian sports news, which is a big change for the better. Local games are also talked about on sports channels in other languages, like Star Sports Tamil, and in the "city" sections of national newspapers.

11.3.2 Print Media and Sports Reporting

M.V. Kamath in the July-September 2008 issue of *Media Mimansa*, states that S. Sadanand's 'Free Press Journal' was the first newspaper in India to devote an entire page to sports with the well-known cricket commentator A.F.S. Talyarkhan as the sports editor. In late thirties, the Bombay (now Mumbai) edition of Times of India started a distinct sports page. Though a few magazines and a few newspapers were publishing news related to sports, yet it was only in the post-independence era that the idea of a regular sports page took importance in Indian newspapers.

Rangaswamy Parthasarathy in "A Hundred Years of *The Hindu*" calls Kasturi Gopalan, the publisher, as the father of sports page for allotting a distinct section to sports in a daily newspaper for the first time, helped by Murugesamudaliar, sportsman in college days and the first sports writer of The Hindu. In fact, the sports journal 'Sports and Past Time' was also published by the same publication in 1947. The Ananda Bazar Patrika group in mid 1970s published 'Sports World' from Calcutta (now Kolkata). Another worthy mention would be the Chennai based fortnightly magazine 'Sportstar' which is being published for the past forty years now and has changed from tabloid to magazine format and vice versa quite a time in its history.

Few other successful sports magazines in India are- ‘Golf Digest India’, ‘Cricket Samrat’, ‘Bike India’, ‘Cricinfo magazine’, etc. Kishore Bhimani, K. Sundar Rajan, Moti Nandi, V. M. Balachandran and T. D. Parthasarathy are some of the notable sports journalists of the print media. After the advent of television the focus of print media shifted from ‘What’ to ‘Why’ factor and the intricate reporting format.

Activity - 1

Analysing the Role of Sports Photography in Sports Journalism

In this activity, you will gauge the importance of sports photography in sports journalism by examining the sports section of a newspaper and determining the space devoted to pictures. You will need a physical or digital newspaper, a ruler or measuring tool, and a calculator to calculate the proportions of images and text to highlight the visual impact of sports photography in conveying stories and emotions to readers.

11.3.3 Radio & TV and Sports Reporting

During the mid twentieth century when around 80 percent people lived in villages and depended on agriculture for their living, Radio was the most apt media for them for definite reasons. Illiteracy was a roadblock for the rural populace to access print media while electricity expenses were a hindrance to access television. Radio was not only portable and inexpensive, but it also allowed the liberty to listen to while people worked on the fields. In India, ‘live’ cricket commentary was heard in 1934 for the first time during the Bombay Quadrangular — a tournament played between teams representing the Hindus, the Muslims, the Parsis and the Europeans.

However, sports broadcasting over Radio took off only in 1960s in the country. Initially, the broadcast of sports commentary in English made it difficult for the common people to understand and enjoy the programme. But Radio sports broadcasting in India got revolutionized with the onset of sports commentary in Hindi and availability of low cost transistors in the 60s. In the absence of television, internet or mobile mediums, Radio remained the unchallenged favorite for sports broadcasting for decades. In the year 2018, India’s first Radio sports channel was launched which covered almost all Olympic games through talk shows, news bulletins, audio documentaries, live commentaries, phone-in etc. The shows, broadcast on this Radio channel in Hindi and English, can be reached 24X7 through mobile app named ‘Sports Flashes’.

The Asian Games of 1982 was hosted by India and the games were held in Delhi. It was a matter of prestige for India to cover and broadcast the games over television. Colour television was introduced in the country in the same year. Just a year later, India won cricket world cup of 1983. To promote television viewing, the then government reduced excise duty on television manufacturing in the country, leading to price drop of television sets. People started getting TV sets to their houses. Doordarshan, the national broadcaster had monopoly over the broadcast of matches and sports events for several

years. In the eighties, the DD show “The World of Sports”, broadcast at 04:30 pm every Sunday was quite popular. It featured talks on cricket, hockey, football, tennis and others. In the year 1999, Doordarshan launched DD Sports, which has been promoting domestic sports on the free-to-air platform. Some of its popular sports programmes are “Sports Konnect”, “Indian Khel League- Yeh India ka KhelHai”, “Guru-Shishya Parampara” and “Fit Rahe India- Healthy living, Wealthy living”.

Some of the popular private sports channels in India are- Star Sports , Star Sports Hindi and Star Sports Tamil, Sony Ten, Neo Prime and Neo Sports, DSport, Jio Sports etc.

11.3.4 Reporting Sports in Online Media

In February 1996, rediff.com began ball-by-ball text commentary. Adapting the digital platform is no longer a strategy but it has become rather a necessity for print and other media forms.

Indian online sports reporting has experienced significant growth in recent years, with numerous websites and mobile applications dedicated to covering various sporting events and activities. This expansion can be attributed to the increased interest in sports, the rise in internet penetration, and the proliferation of smartphones in India.

The online sports reporting landscape in India is characterized by a mix of traditional news outlets with dedicated sports sections, specialized sports websites, and social media channels that focus on sports. The content ranges from live match updates, in-depth articles, analysis, and interviews to multimedia features like videos, podcasts, and photo galleries.

Several technology enabled sports news platforms are producing internet content, covering various games and events. Today most of the sporting events are telecast online via HOTSTAR and SONY LIV app over mobile phones. Several sports web portals, blogs and sports news websites have become popular amongst sports lovers.

11.4 WRITING SPORTS NEWS REPORTS

Writing sports stories requires proper background research and planning. The story is weaved keeping in mind the following:

- a) the medium through which the story shall be broadcast or published; and
- b) the expectations and preferences of the target audience or readers of the story.

Writing sports stories has four main steps:

- generation of a story idea;
- understanding the issue;
- collection of data, statistics, statements of major stakeholders, and
- writing

Headline, lead and body are three main parts of a sports report or story. There is no fixed formulae or template to write a great story. The format and style depends on the subject chosen. While a sports event or match result story will mostly have 5 W, 1 H format, a profile or human interest story talking about struggle, behavior, opinion, lifestyle will have an elaborate feature style.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space given below for your answer

2) Compare your answer with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. List your five favorite sports programmes on television.

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2. Name five best sports websites/apps according to you.

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3. Write brief note on a few sports magazines published in India.

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11.5 SPORTS REPORTER :SKILLS AND QUALITIES

Sports reporters tell us about all kinds of local, national, and foreign sporting events and news. He or she gathers, puts together, and shares knowledge about current sports events and issues. Reporters are essential to any news organization. People often call them the "foot soldiers" of a media company. In today's age of journalism, sports is a unique beat. So, let us take a look at the basic skills and qualities of a sports reporter.

- **Experience of Sports or Passion for sports:** A sports reporter needs to have experienced the sweat and dirt on the field. Even though there have been great commentators who weren't players, having played the sport gives you a deeper understanding of it. It helps the reporters figure out who did the best and who did the worst, which makes their story more interesting to read for the people. As a former player, the writer knows how games work and what the rules are.
- **Knowledge about the economy of Sports:** In the era of globalization, a lot of multinational capital is involved in the sports industry. A sports reporter should understand different aspects of the economy of the sports ecosystem.

- **Understanding of the sports terminology, lingo and vocabulary:** Every sport has its unique terminology. The terms 'push' and 'scoop' have different meanings. The terms 'mount' and 'dismount' in gymnastics cannot be replaced with the terms 'climb' and 'fall'. There are specific terms for the position of players and different color cards of penalty. Similarly, the idioms and phrases for tennis and badminton are different. Knowledge of the technical terms for shots, positions, actions and acquaintance with the stories and idioms for various sports is important for a good sports reporter.
- **Good relations with the sports fraternity:** Friendly relationships with the sports community (players, coaches, and leaders in sports federations, associations, academies, and other related sports institutions) help sports reporters find reliable sources and find out about untold stories.
- **Command over language:** A sports writer must be able to talk in a clear and straightforward way. He or she shouldn't use jargon and should make sure to use correct language and punctuation. A writer must make sure that what they say is clear, logical, correct, complete, and short.
- **Nose for the news, ears to the ground:** As the sports business in India grows, more and more sports-related problems are popping up. Investigative stories about sports crimes, fights, and controversies, gender discrimination, and policy choices in sports need to be done quickly and followed up on often. A sports writer needs to know the difference between "news" and "information" in order to do their job well.
- **Creativity and curiosity:** A good sports reporter is always interested in what's going on. When you want to know more, you look for good stories. Creativity comes from trying to see things from different points of view. We often see that even though different newspapers or TV stations report the same event or win, one "out-of-the-box" headline or angle is what draws most people to it.
- **Knowledge of sports laws:** A sports reporter should know about labour, antitrust, gender discrimination, trademarks, copyrights, contract, tort, and relevant laws. Rather than being a discrete area of law, 'sports law' is often seen as the application of various areas of law to the sports industry. If a sports reporter knows about the above rules, s/he will be better able to follow the legal issues in the sports world.
- **Ability of multitasking:** There are strict deadlines for getting news and sending reports and stories. Many times, there are several sports events that need to be covered on the same day. In this age of "breaking news," a sports reporter needs to be "jack of all trades and master of some" to keep up. One must be good with technology, know how to use a camera on their own, be able to edit and package shows, create pages for newspapers and magazines, and be able to give good presentations.

- **Ability to understand the perspective of audience/readers:** A good sports reporter understands his/her target audience or readers.
- **Truth and objectivity:** It might be hard for a sports fan to watch a game without taking a side. But sports journalists can't afford to take sides when they write stories or reports. In the long run, people will believe a journalist who is honest and fair. Information must be checked and rechecked, and a report must be based on facts. People will stop accepting a sports reporter's reports and stories if he or she is biased.

11.5.1 'Do's and don'ts for a Sports Reporter

Some 'do's and don'ts for a sports reporter are as follows:

- Use short sentences.
- Use correct grammar and punctuation.
- Use appropriate sports terminologies.
- Be creative and think 'out-of-the-box'.
- Remember the 5 Ws and 1 H.
- Prefer the inverted pyramid writing style for hard news.
- Avoid jargons.
- Remember the 5 Cs of communication - clear, coherent, correct, comprehensive and concise.
- Do not use many numbers in your reports.
- Check facts and be accurate.
- Authenticate reports with statements of authorities.
- Get firsthand information. Watch matches before filing your report.
- Keep yourself updated.
- Place ethics at the foremost in the order of importance.
- Choose the format and style of report/article as per the issue and theme

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space given below for your answer

2) Compare your answer with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. Why are sources important for a sports reporter?

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2. How important is the knowledge of sports law for a sports reporter. Explain

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3. What are the important qualities of a sports reporter ?

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11.6 TRENDS IN SPORTS REPORTING

Sports journalism today goes well beyond just reporting on sporting events. It discusses the effects of the course of events and a variety of topics, including gender equality, the law, trends, scandals and controversies, diplomatic choices, public opinion, the formulation of policy, and the economics of the sports market. Also, sport is so dynamic a stream that the trends change very fast. Be it designing, reporting, commentary or live streaming, let us take a look at the emerging trends in sports reporting:

- Sports journalism is increasingly turning into a specialized stream from being a small part of a news bulletin, to 30-60 minutes shows based on specific games like- ‘Cricket Controversy’ or ‘KissaKicket Ka’ to full-fledged 24X7 sports channels, or entire magazines devoted to a specific game. Sports beat has become an important area of journalism in the last decade or so.
- Sports journalism is now an expensive affair. The amount of money going into sports journalism has expanded along with the growth of sponsorships and advertisements. Today's sports coverage includes high-tech microphones, lenses, outfits, and accessories.
- Sports getting space on the front page of newspapers and featuring during prime time on television news channels is a positive trend.
- Media outlets sensationalize sporting events, controversies, statements made by famous players, and other details of their personal lives to increase their TRP or circulation. Sporting victories frequently sounds like war victories in the headlines.
- It is quite encouraging that today we see news of domestic sports, inter-university games, and sports news from cities etc. being covered by the mainstream media.
- Sports columns and write ups by renowned players and coaches are becoming popular amidst sports lovers.
- Players' social media tweets and postings about current events, problems, or their personal lives are read by large audiences and frequently make news.
- ‘Athlete Driven Media’ is a trend quite popular in western countries today and is catching up in India as well. In this concept, sports persons directly share their take on an issue through social media instead of approaching mainstream media to cover their statements. This kind of ‘no filter’, ‘uncut’ communication of sports persons directly with masses is certainly in fashion.

- With social media and open publishing forums, the trend of sports enthusiasts analyzing and writing stories is on the rise.
- The revamp of sports other than cricket and traditional Indian sports is quite an encouraging phenomena today.

Check Your Progress 3

Note: 1) Use the space given below for your answer

2) Compare your answer with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. What points should be kept in mind while writing sports reports or stories ?

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11.7 LET US SUM UP

We discussed the history of sports journalism in India briefly. We learned the advantages of sports for our bodies, minds, and spirits, and we examined how the Indian sports business has grown in the twenty-first century. We discussed the growth and variety of sports coverage in print (newspapers and magazines) media, electronic (radio and television) media and online media (blogs, websites, e-papers). The qualities and skills required in a sports reporter were also elaborated in the Unit. We also went into great detail on the new trends in sports reporting. We also discussed the important considerations for sports reporting and writing.

11.8 FURTHER READINGS

Lambert, C. M. (2018). Digital Sports Journalism. Routledge.

Reinardy, S., & Wanta, W. (2015). The essentials of sports reporting and writing. Routledge.

11.9 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

1. Answer this question as per your choice.
2. Answer this question as per your opinion.
3. Sports magazines published in India:- 'Cricket Samrat' is a Hindi language magazine published since 1980 is exclusively about cricket. 'Golf Digest India' covers the game of golf. 'Bike India' is based on racing and 'Kushti' is based on wrestling. 'The Himalayan Journal' is an Indian annual magazine in the category of climbing and mountaineering.

Check Your Progress 2

1. Sources are extremely important for a sports reporter. Credible sources help in getting leads for stories. A sports journalist has to maintain good relations with players, coaches, lawyers, audiences, peer journalists, federation and association officials etc. to obtain authentic sports stories.
2. The knowledge of sports laws is extremely important for a sports reporter. Today sports journalism is much beyond writing about win and loss. It is more about analysis and issues. Be it gender discrimination, doping and drug abuse or controversies and cases like breach of contract etc., sports reporter cannot write on these matters until and unless one understands sports law.

3. The important qualities of a sports reporter are as follows:

Creativity and confidence; Knowledge and passion for sports; Command over sports vocabulary, rules, technicalities; Knowledge of sports law; Good relations with stakeholders of sports; Truth and honesty; Eye for detail and accuracy; Nose for the news and ears to the ground (News Sense); Understanding of sports economy; and In-depth understanding of issues related to sports industry.

Check Your Progress 3

1. Some of the key points to be kept in mind while writing sports reports or stories are truth, detail, rules, creativity, accuracy, fairness, target audience, medium, 5 Cs, 5 Ws, 1 H, etc.

UNIT 12 CRIME REPORTING

Structure

- 12.0 Introduction
- 12.1 Learning Outcomes
- 12.2 Crime Beat: An Introduction
 - 12.2.1 Crime, Court and Police
 - 12.2.2 Areas covered under Crime Beat
 - 12.2.3 Sources of Crime Reporting
- 12.3 Role, Importance and trends of Crime Reporting
 - 12.3.1 Roles of Crime Reporting
 - 12.3.2 Importance of Crime Reporting
 - 12.3.3 Trends
- 12.4 Eligibility and Qualities of a Crime Reporter
- 12.5 Crime Reporting: Useful Tips
- 12.6 Important Codes
- 12.7 Let Us Sum Up
- 12.8 Further Readings
- 12.9 Check Your Progress: Possible Answers

12.0 INTRODUCTION

Crime is the bitter truth of our society and it is an important reporting beat in journalism. You can find a large number of crime stories in newspapers, television news channels and news websites. In news channels, you even find dedicated bulletins or shows on crime.

In this unit, we'll discuss different aspects of crime reporting. What is crime? Why is it important to report crime? What are the possible sources of crime reporting? What are the eligibility and qualities of a crime reporter? In this unit, you will also learn about the meaning, needs, importance, concept and trends of crime reporting.

12.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After going through this unit, you will be able to:

- explain the importance of crime reporting;
- discuss the different types and sources of crime reporting;
- describe the qualities of a good crime reporter; and
- know the precautions that a crime reporter should take.

12.2 CRIME BEAT: AN INTRODUCTION

‘Crime’ is one of the most important beats in the field of journalism. Among the three essential C’s of Media (Crime, Cricket and Cinema), crime reports are the most read and sold news item which have become major sources of revenue for media organizations. Several news channels telecast regular bulletins on crime news. Hence, covering crime is a major responsibility for journalists. The role of police and court is very important in crime beat, hence it is essential for a journalist to understand the definition of crime, court and police.

12.2.1 Crime, Court and Police

Crime can be considered one of the biggest problems of any society. It harms the individual and affects the humanity as a whole. Police and courts have emerged as institutions in order to handle crime. Without police, crime cannot be controlled and without courts impartial judgment can’t be delivered. So both the ‘Cs’ (Crime & Court) and one ‘P’ (Police) are interlinked. Now, we will discuss the definitions of crime, court and police.

Definitions of Crime:

- Duhaime’s Law Dictionary defines it as an act or omission which is prohibited by criminal law and punished, usually by fine or imprisonment.
- Oxford Dictionary defines crime as an act punishable by law as forbidden by statute or injurious to the public welfare.
- Merriam Webster defines it as an illegal act for which someone can be punished by the government.
- Farlex dictionary defines it as a violation of a law in which there is injury to the public or a member of the public and a term in jail or prison, and/or a fine as possible penalties.
- Sir William Blackstone in his ‘Commentaries on the Laws of England’ defined Crime as “an act committed or omitted in violation of Public Law forbidding or commanding it”
- Prof. Hazel Croall defined crime in his book ‘Crime and Society in Britain’ as ‘something which is against the criminal law’.
- Kirby et al (2000) defined crime as ‘behavior that breaks the formal written laws of a given society’.
- CrPC 1973 has defined that any act or omission made punishable by any law for the time being in force.

Types of Crime: According to www.legalmatch.com, crimes can be divided into four following major categories:

1. Personal Crimes – ‘Offenses against the Person’: These are crimes that result in physical or mental harm to another person.
2. Property Crimes – ‘Offenses against Property’: These are crimes that do

not necessarily involve harm to another person. Instead, they involve an interference with another person's right to use or enjoy their property.

3. **Inchoate Crimes:** 'Inchoate' translates into 'incomplete', meaning crimes that were begun, but not completed. This requires that a person take a substantial step to complete a crime, as opposed to just 'intend' to commit a crime.
4. **Statutory Crimes:** A violation of a specific state or federal statute and can involve either property offenses or personal offenses.

Definitions of Court

- **Oxford Dictionary** defines court as a body of people presided over by a judge, judges or magistrate, and acting as a tribunal in civil and criminal cases.
- **Cambridge Dictionary** (Online) defines the court as a place where trials and other proceedings of legal cases take place or the people present in such a place, especially the officials and those deciding if someone is guilty.
- **Merriam Webster** defines:
 - i. A formal legal meeting in which evidence about crimes, disagreements, etc., is presented to a judge or often a jury so that decisions can be made according to the law.
 - ii. A place where legal cases are heard.
 - iii. An official group of people (such as a judge and jury) who listen to evidence and make decisions about legal cases.
- **Macmillan Dictionary** defines court as a place where trials take place and legal cases are decided, especially in front of a judge and a jury or a magistrate.

Types of Courts in India:

- **Supreme Court:** The highest court of India or apex judicial forum and final court to appeal. Supreme court of India established by the Constitution of India.
- **High Courts:** The highest court of the state or union territories.
- **Tribunals and Appellate Boards:** These tribunals and appellate boards are constituted for a specific purpose.
- **District and Session Courts:** Every state is divided into several districts jurisdiction. Every district has own court. These courts are called district and session courts.

Definitions of Police:

- The First Police Commission, appointed on 17 August 1865, contained detailed guidelines for the desired system of police in India and defined the police as a governmental department to maintain order, enforce the law, and to prevent and detect crime.

- **Farlex Dictionary** defines the police as a body of government employees trained in methods of law enforcement, crime prevention and detection and authorized to maintain the peace, safety, and order of the community.
- **Oxford Dictionary** defines police as the civil force of a state responsible for the prevention, detection of crime and the maintenance of public order.
- **Cambridge Dictionary** (Online) defines police as the official organization that is responsible for protecting people and property, making people obey the law, finding out about and solving crime, and catching people who have committed a crime.
- **Macmillan Dictionary** defines police as the people who work for an organization that tries to catch criminals and checks that people obey the law.

According to National Police Commission set up by the Government of India in 1977, the following are the duties and responsibilities of the police:

- To promote and preserve public order.
- Investigate crimes.
- Identify problems and situations that are likely lead to crimes.
- Reduce the opportunities for the commission of crimes through preventive patrol and other police measures.
- Aid and cooperate with other relevant agencies in implementing appropriate measures for prevention of crime.
- Aid individuals who are in danger of physical harm.
- Create and maintain a feeling of security in the community.
- Facilitate orderly movement of people and vehicles.
- Provide other appropriate services and relief to people in distress.
- Counsel and resolve conflicts and promote amity.
- Collect intelligence reports relating to matters affecting public peace and crime in general including social and economic offences, national integrity and security.

12.2.2 Areas Covered Under Crime Beat

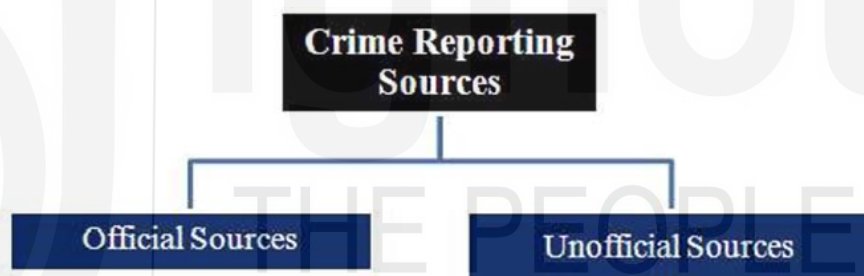
The various kinds of act that come under the purview of crime reporting are the following:

- Offences relating to human body : These include murder, assassination, culpable homicide, abetment of suicide, attempt to murder, attempt to commit suicide, kidnapping, abduction, slavery, rape, forced labor, etc.
- Offences against property: These include theft, extortion, blackmail, robbery, criminal breach of trust, criminal trespass, cheating by impersonation, arson, receiving stolen property or assisting in its concealment.

- Offences related to documents and trade: These include criminal breach of contract and services, defamatory printed matters, criminal intimidation, insult and annoyance.
- Obstructing justice : These offences include interfering with an officer, perjury, bribery and contempt of court.
- Other criminal offences include terrorists' violence, genocide, illegal beverages, sale of drugs, riots, sexual crimes, accidents and police encounter.
- Accidents : All types of transportation related accidents, such as road, train, plane, etc.; work accidents/factory accidents; deaths and harms due to negligence.
- Event reporting : Press conferences/briefing at police HQ, police day events, events organized by police, new policies and technologies introduced in policing, etc.

12.2.3 Crime Reporting: Sources

Sources play a crucial role in crime reporting. There are several sources that provide information to a crime reporter. These sources may be classified into two categories - official and unofficial sources.



Official Sources : Some important official sources for a crime reporter are as follows:

- Police's Press Release/Note
- Police's Press Conference/Briefing
- Police's PRO office
- Police Websites
- Emergency Dials-112, 100, 101, 102 etc
- Police Stations
- Police Official Sources
- Hospitals and PROs
- Annual Reports
- Courts and Court officials
- Advocates
- National and state Commissions like - Women Commissions, Human Rights Commissions etc.

- Crime record related organizations such as National Crime Records Bureau.
- Special Agencies- CBI, NIA etc.

Unofficial Sources : Some important unofficial sources for crime reporting are as follows:

- Victim
- Passer-by
- Eye witness
- Accused
- Offender
- Police informers
- Other news organizations (Newspapers, TV news channels, News Websites)
- Social media

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space given below for your answer
2) Compare your answer with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. What is crime beat?

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2. Discuss the unofficial sources of crime reporting.

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12.3 ROLE, IMPORTANCE AND TRENDS OF CRIME REPORTING

In this section we shall discuss what are the roles, importance and trends of crime reporting.

12.3.1 Roles of Crime Reporting

The important roles of crime reporting are:

To create awareness: Reporting crime is required to make the people aware about different types of crime, criminals and their modus operandi. Many crime news stories inform us about the threats of different criminal gangs active in a particular area. Let us understand by the following examples:

Beware of criminals on Indian cyberspace in the upcoming big billion days

If you enticed by the offers on cyberspace, think twice before clicking. You could be seconds away from getting duped.

Ankit Singh, a resident of Malviya Nagar in south Delhi, ordered an iPhone 7 after he got a link on one of his WhatsApp groups this week, which offered the latest model at one-third of its market price. The link took him to a leading online shopping look-a-like portal. The website said that the offer expires in the next three minutes, and so without cross-checking it, Singh booked the phone. However, he got the shock of his life when he later realised that he had been duped by online fraudsters.

Beware, Indian cyberspace is brimming with a variety of fraudulent offers, from attractive deals to anything that is part of the most current shopping craze, as online sales for Dussehra and Diwali are picking up pace. (Published by www.indiatoday.in)

To educate: Sometimes, crime news stories may educate the people. They provide new facts and knowledge. For example, you may see the following crime news published by www.republicworld.com

Indore Central Jail helps prisoners to get education

In a bid to help prisoners change their lives after their release from prison, Indore Central Jail is assisting them by providing education. According to reports, a total of 253 candidates took part in the examination this year, which was organized by the Indore Jail. While in 2019, the Indore Central Jail provided degrees to 60 prisoners. The Central Jail is teaching different subjects to the prisoners' studies.

A total of 63 subjects from the Indira Gandhi National Open University (IGNOU) are being provided to the prisoners. They are studying various subjects, including MBA, M. Com, etc. and are doing good work after being released. "We are also in touch with such people. They are living a good life. When a prisoner starts studying in their old age, other prisoners also take inspiration from him and they also start studying, "said the jail superintendent. (Published by www.republicworld.com)

To inform - Many a times crime news inform us about what to do what not to do. For example, if a crime story tells about the Delhi Police's campaign of checking pollution certificates and fining the violators, it'll inform the citizens of Delhi in advance so that they can check their vehicles' pollution certificates and follow the rules to avoid paying penalty.

To motivate- Sometimes crime news motivates the public to become sensitive to crime and related social issues. Recall the incident of gang rape in 2012 in Delhi. Reporting of this incident had created a mass movement that made the common people sensitive to horrible and violent crimes against women.

To expose: Crime reports expose the criminal elements of the society and those who want to keep information secret. In this situation, investigation

plays a major role in reporting crime. In many cases, police, bureaucrats, politicians etc. want to hide several information and this is where the role of crime reporter starts.

12.3.2 Importance of Crime Reporting

After discussing the roles of crime reporting, now it is clear that this beat is very significant. Crime reporting is important for society, police and also for media organizations.

Importance of crime reporting for society: To eradicate the criminal elements from the society, to report the crime, helpful to achieve justice, social reform, watchdog of the society, keeping people alert from crime and criminals.

Importance of crime reporting for police: To control the crime, to investigate the cases, to propagate the information, to set the agenda, to improve the image of police, fair trial, to aware the mass regarding policing or police working.

Importance of crime reporting for media organizations: To increase readership, circulation or viewership, to generate revenue, to fulfill the professional responsibility of news media organizations.

13.3.3 Trends

After the emergence of 24X7 television journalism, the presentation of news has drastically changed especially in the case of crime news. Here, we will discuss some trends in reporting and presenting crime stories which can be positive or negative.

Positive Trends:

1. **More informative:** Nowadays, in crime stories, journalists want to cover every dimension and aspect of the story. More research is used in presenting crime news.
2. **More investigative:** Investigation is crucial for crime reporting. Nowadays we can see more investigation and angles in crime reporting.
3. **More Engaging:** The presentation of crime stories has become more engaging. On television and online platforms (videos), crime reports are now presented with sound effects, visual effects, animations and graphics. Recreation of events is also used in crime stories.
4. **Speedy:** Now we are living in the world of advanced information technology where information reaches us at a very quick pace. Television and online media provide crime news and their updates immediately.
5. **Follow up:** Every reader or viewer wants to be more updated about the incidents of crime happening in and around their area. News organizations fulfill this desire by following up on the crime incidents from the spot to the court.

Negative Trends:

1. **Dramatization:** To attract more readers or viewers, often dramatization is used in the presentation of crime news. You can watch many crime shows on television news channels produced with full of dramatization.
2. **Exaggeration:** In this era of fierce competition, crime stories with exaggerations are used to attract readers or viewers. This trend, however, puts the credibility of the news at stake.
3. **Sensationalization:** These days, sensationalized crime reports are quite common. This tendency defeats the purpose of serious and ethical journalism.
4. **Media Trail:** Media trial is a major problem of crime journalism. Many a times the media presents an accused as guilty much before the actual judgement of the court. It is against the principles of journalism. An accused is only an accused until the court considers him or her guilty.
5. **Telephonic Reporting:** Collecting information from ground zero is always the best way of crime reporting but the tendency to get information on telephone is increasing among the crime reporters due to various reasons. This can lead to loss of credibility.
6. **Complete dependence on police diary/record:** Police diary or record is one of the main sources in crime reporting but complete dependency on it is not advisable for a good crime reporter. Reporter's own investigation and analysis are must for fair reporting. But these days trend of police diary based reporting is increasing.

Activity 1

Read any newspaper. Select crime news stories and try to measure its share in the total news content of that newspaper. Repeat this exercise for a week and find the average share of crime news in that newspaper.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space given below for your answer.

2) Compare your answer with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. Describe the roles of crime reporting.

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2. List the five positive trends in crime reporting.

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12.4 ELIGIBILITY AND QUALITIES OF CRIME REPORTER

What qualifications are necessary to become a crime reporter and what are the qualities that a good crime reporter should have? Let us discuss in detail.

Qualities for a good crime reporter

- Knowledge of police functioning
- Good knowledge of relevant laws
- News Sense
- Writing Skill
- Knowledge of Court System
- Investigative Ability
- Analytical Ability
- Alertness
- Curiosity
- Skeptical
- Fearlessness
- Self-Discipline
- Forthrightness
- Meeting Deadlines
- Presence of Mind

Eligibilities (Generally) for being a crime reporter

- Graduate/Post Graduate/PG Diploma/ Diploma in Journalism & Mass Communication
- Knowledge of the relevant languages
- Any formal degree/diploma in law enhances the suitability

12.5 CRIME REPORTING: USEFUL TIPS

- Careful examination of facts and evidence, and inclusion of all aspects or parties make the crime news credible. Always try to establish the truth. Don't believe anyone blindly, investigate the facts yourself.
- We should not rely blindly on information, stories, evidence provided by the police. While the police diary is the first step towards investigating any crime incident, but report should not be dependent solely on it.
- Be objective and don't include your personal views in your report.
- Continuous follow up of the police investigation of any crime incident is necessary to provide updated reports.
- Don't sensationalize crime incidents in news reports. Crime incident itself is a sensational matter.
- Don't behave like police or court. The duty of media is only to inform

the public about the crime objectively. Do not try to give a decision before the court delivers its judgment. Media trial must be avoided and don't present accused as guilty before the court's verdict is out.

- You may face pressure coming from different influential parties but always try to be objective.
- Competition to break any exclusive news is good but it should not be done in hurried manner. Check and verify the information before delivering the report.
- Information should be kept as information only. The glorification of information is always fatal. Don't exaggerate the crime stories.
- Use simple and clear language for crime reports.
- When covering the occurrence of any crime, the reporter must take into account social interests as well as personal interests. Do not hurt the feelings of victims or innocent people.
- Reporter should respect the rights of both the victims and the accused.
- Try to strengthen the network of your sources. A crime reporter's life is nothing without reliable sources.

12.6 IMPORTANT CODES

IPC or Indian Penal Code is the official criminal code of our country. It is a comprehensive code which covers all main aspects of criminal law. On the other hand, CrPC or the Code of Criminal Procedure (CrPC) is the key legislation on procedure for administration of substantive criminal law in India. But now Government of India is in process to overhaul these codes. On 11th August 2023 the union home minister introduced three bills in the Lok Sabha - Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), 2023, to replace the IPC; Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), 2023, for CrPC; and Bharatiya Sakshya (BS) Bill, 2023, for the Indian Evidence Act. A good crime reporter should know the important sections of these codes.

Check Your Progress 3

Note: 1) Use the space given below for your answer

2) Compare your answer with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. What are qualities of good crime reporter ?

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12.7 LET US SUM UP

We have discussed the various aspects of crime reporting in this unit. Crime reporting is an important beat of journalism. In order to report crime related news, it is necessary that the reporter should have good knowledge of law, police and court. Crime reporting for various media such as print, radio, TV

and online is also discussed in this unit. This unit gives you many tips for good crime reporting and also discusses the qualities of a good crime reporter.

12.8 FURTHER READINGS

Schlesinger, P., & Tumber, H. (1994). Reporting crime: The media politics of criminal justice. Oxford: Clarendon Press.

Trager, R., Ross, S. D., & Reynolds, A. (2017). The law of journalism and mass communication. Cq Press.

12.9 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

1. Crime is an act punishable by law as forbidden by statute or injurious to the public welfare. And crime beat is an area of reporting which covers the crime related news stories.
2. The unofficial sources of crime reporting are following :
 - Victim
 - Passer-by
 - Eye witness
 - Accused
 - Offender
 - Police informers
 - Other news organizations (Newspapers, TV news channels, News Websites)
 - Social media

Check Your Progress 2

1. The roles of crime reporting are as follows:
 - To create awareness
 - To educate
 - To inform
 - To motivate
 - To expose
2. Five positive trends in crime reporting are following:
 - i. More informative: Now in crime stories, journalists want to cover every dimension and aspect of the story. More research is used in presenting crime news.
 - ii. More investigative: Investigation is crucial for crime reporting. Nowadays we can see more investigation and angles in crime reporting.
 - iii. More Engaging: The presentation of crime stories has become more

engaging. On television and online platforms (videos), crime reports are now presented with sound effects, visual effects, animations and graphics. Recreation of events is also used in crime stories.

- iv. Speedy: Now we are living in the world of advanced information technology, where information reaches us at a very quick pace. Television and online media provide crime news and their updates immediately.
- v. Follow up: Every reader or viewer wants to be more updated about the incidents of crime happening in and around the area. News organizations fulfill this desire by following up the crime incidents from spot to court.

Check Your Progress 3

1. Qualities of a good crime reporter are following:
 - News Sense
 - Writing Skill, Investigative Ability, Alertness
 - Curiosity, Skeptical, Fearlessness, Forthrightness
 - Good knowledge of IPC, CrPC and other laws; Self-discipline.

UNIT 13 LEGAL REPORTING

Structure

- 13.0 Introduction
- 13.1 Learning Outcomes
- 13.2 Legal Reporting is an Art
- 13.3 The Court Beat: An Introduction
 - 13.3.1 The Justice System
 - 13.3.2 Why Report Court Cases?
- 13.4 Legal Reporter: Knowledge and News Sources
 - 13.4.1 Important Legal Terms
 - 13.4.2 News Sources
 - 13.4.3 Coverage of a Trial
- 13.5 Essential Elements of a Court Story
- 13.6 Precautions Necessary in Legal Reporting
 - 13.6.1 Civil Contempt
 - 13.6.2 Criminal Contempt
 - 13.6.3 Scandalising the Court
 - 13.6.4 Trial by Media
- 13.7 Journalistic Defences
 - 13.7.1 Fair Comments
 - 13.7.2 Heard and Finally Decided
 - 13.7.3 Ignorance of Pendency
 - 13.7.4 Fair and Accurate Report
 - 13.7.5 Amendment of 2006 to Contempt of Court Act, 1971
 - 13.7.6 Academic Writing
- 13.8 Punishment
- 13.9 In Camera Proceedings
- 13.10 Let Us Sum Up
- 13.11 Further Readings
- 13.12 Check Your Progress: Possible Answers

13.0 INTRODUCTION

This unit will give you a brief overview of issues related to legal reporting. It will inform you about the importance of court beat and the provisions of Contempt of Court Act, 1971. In this unit the essentials of court reporting have also been discussed along with sources of legal Reporter. The unit will further deal with subject of trial by media, Civil and Criminal Contempt and related topics.

13.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After going through this unit, you should be able to:

- discuss the major issues related to court reporting;
- understand justice system and trial by media;
- know the implications of Contempt of Court Act, 1971 for a legal/court reporter;
- describe the news sources of legal reporter; and
- know the essential elements and ethics of legal reporting.

13.2 LEGAL REPORTING IS AN ART

Legal Reporting is synonymous with court reporting which covers court verdicts, judiciary conditions, national laws, proceedings of court cases and the legal trends. Sometimes you may also find interviews of lawyers, judges or the reports on their speeches in public. The significance of legal reporting has highly increased in India with the increasing number of court cases. One of the reason for the increase may be that the courts are now getting more active in the field of social justice.

Legal reporting is also considered an art which is learned, cultivated and developed by spending time in courts watching cases, writing them up day after day and improving by practice. It is the reporter who finds out the interesting and newsworthy content from the routine normal events in the courts and converts them into readable news reports. A good court reporter will always produce something readable and newsworthy. The Legal report is operated with constraints which are highly focused on the key facts. The reporting has to be accurate, unbiased and disciplined.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space given below for your answer.

2) Compare your answer with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. What is legal reporting?

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2. Why is court reporting an art?

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13.3 THE COURT BEAT: AN INTRODUCTION

For any media house it is not possible to keep one court reporter in every court. They simply do not have adequate resources to cover all the courts in their main circulation area. Moreover, newspapers as well as broadcast media neither have the time nor the space to cover everything that happens in the courts. They cover only those stories in which their readers or viewers are interested. Many court rooms also has a separate press gallery. Indian courts are also opening themselves for recording and broadcasting gradually. In September 2018, the Supreme Court of India has allowed live-streaming of court proceedings of cases of constitutional importance. Apart from this, courts have been using video conference facilities for their proceedings. The argument in favour of televising court proceedings is that it will create more transparency.

While reporting court stories the emphasis of the news media is on criminal courts, High Courts and the Supreme Court. It has been observed that media are less interested in covering civil courts. One of the reasons for this lack of interest may be that people in general are more interested in criminal stories than the news stories related to civil suits.

13.3.1 The Justice System

India follows an independent judiciary system to interpret the law and administer justice to all citizens. As media is considered the watch dog of the society, the Indian judiciary is considered the guardian of the constitution.

India follows a single integrated judicial structure with Supreme Court (SC) on the top, then the High Courts followed by district courts.

Supreme Court (SC): This is the most powerful court whose decisions are binding on all courts. It can transfer judges, move cases or even transfer cases from one court to another.

High Court: They can hear cases within the jurisdiction of state and control over district and subordinate courts. Depending on the size, history, convenience of the states, some of the High Courts have more benches in other cities in addition to their principal seats.

District Court/ Session Courts: District courts primarily deal with civil cases, whereas sessions courts essentially try criminal cases. There are special courts: CBI courts, fast track courts, etc. which are constituted to deal with matters supposed to be very important for public life.

13.3.2 Why Report Court Cases?

Legal reporting for the purpose of journalism and mass communication primarily means reporting court cases. Almost every case that comes before the courts involves human interest. Murders and rapes, thefts and burglaries, scams and broken promises are news because they involve human interest. Every one of these stories if written properly is of human interest. On the other hand, they inform readers about the workings of the courts.

We could find three main reasons why media report court cases: to satisfy people's appetite for knowing as to what is going on in the courts; how important cases are progressing there; and to maintain public confidence in the law of the land

13.4 LEGAL REPORTER: KNOWLEDGE AND NEWS SOURCES

The vital principle says that the Justice must not just be done but must be seen to be done, hence except few minor exceptions every member of the public can attend the court. Legal reporters work for the news media and it is their duty to attend the important court cases and report the public about the hearings.

The first and foremost thing that every legal or court reporter in India should know, is the hierarchy of courts in the country. Supreme Court of India is the top most court of the country. High Courts come next to the Supreme Court.

The three essential role of legal reporter is to help the law deter crime, encourage public confidence on law and report perfect news stories. Hence legal reporters have an important and responsible role in the society. They must prepare a fair, accurate report without malice. The legal reporters should know about the articles of constitution along with the essential sections of relevant laws.

13.4.1 Important Legal Terms

For a court reporter, some basic knowledge of some of the most frequently used legal terms is a must. The following are some of the legal terms used quite often in the news reports.

Accused: A person who is charged with the commission of an offense.

Adjourn: To postpone the session of a court or any other similar tribunal to another date.

Attachment: The process of legally seizing a property in order to force the person to appear before the court or to ensure that the owner of the said property complies with the decision of the court in a pending suit.

Bail Bond: A security amount usually furnished to guarantee the appearance of an accused person in the court.

Capital Punishment: The sentence of death, awarded to those who commit very serious crimes. It is otherwise known as the death penalty.

Change of Venue: Change of the place of trial.

Commutation: Reduction of sentence.

Concurrent Sentence: Court's decision that a convicted person serves only the longest of several jail terms imposed on him.

Contempt of Court: An offence against the court, punished by a fine, or imprisonment or both.

Circumstantial Evidence: As compared to direct evidence, like the testimony of the eyewitness, circumstantial evidence can be considered as indirect evidence or facts which are inferred from the proven facts. Circumstantial evidence can be best explained with fingerprints, which can prove the presence of a particular person at the crime scene or his/her contact with an object used in the commission of a crime.

Copyright: It gives the owner the exclusive right to control the publication, distribution and adaptation of creative works, for a certain period of time.

Date Rape: Forcible sexual intercourse, while on a voluntary social outing where the women resisted the sexual advances of the man.

Double Jeopardy: Double jeopardy is based on the principle that no person can be punished more than once for the same offense.

Doctrine: A legal doctrine is a rule or principle of law, framework, set of rules, when established by a precedent through which judgments can be determined in a given legal case.

Dying Declaration: A dying declaration is the evidence provided by a person who is on his death bed, and are given the same weightage as regular evidence.

Extradition: Process of returning a prisoner from one country to another.

In Camera: When a legal trial is held before the judge in private chambers, where the public is not permitted to witness it, then it is called an in camera hearing.

Interim Order: A temporary order made by a judge during the trial, until a final order is passed.

Jump Bail: When a person fails to attend court after s/he is released on depositing bail, s/he is said to jump bail.

Habeas Corpus: Judicial procedure requiring production of a detained person in court to inquire into the legality of the detention.

Pardon: Action of executive relieving criminal from sentence.

Parole: Release before the completion of the sentence on promise of reappearance at regular intervals or on call.

Plaintiff: Party who initiates litigation.

Suo Moto Proceedings: Proceedings launched by the court on its own.

Reprieve: Delay in execution of a sentence.

Respondent: Party against whom an appeal has been taken.

Each legal term to be explained briefly when it is used in a story for the first time. Unexplained legal term confuses the reader. News story should also not be cluttered up with too much legal jargon.

13.4.2 News Sources for Legal Reporters

Much of a reporter's success in the coverage of the courts depends on one's contacts and sources, and one's ability to gain access quickly to the records. For a reporter, the key person in a court is the clerk of the court. A court clerk prepares and keeps the records. S/he can make available copies of transcript for a fee. Court reporting involves diligent checking of records. Reporter should also have good contacts with the lawyers. The reporter must also ensure impartial reportage of the court's proceedings.

It is not unusual for the parties and lawyers to approach a journalist and present their case afresh. A young reporter should always try to seek some impartial legal source, usually a friendly lawyer, to learn what moves are likely to be made.

13.4.3 Coverage of a Trial

While taking notes in trial coverage the reporter needs to have sixth sense. Guided by this news sense, s/he could begin to take notes of important dates. When a reporter misses an important point, one can always regain lost ground during the recess by consulting his/her colleagues in the court, or the court stenographer.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space given below for your answer

2) Compare your answer with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. Write the names of any two High Courts which have benches in addition to their principal seat.

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2. What are the arguments in favour of the live telecast of court proceedings?

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13.5 ESSENTIAL ELEMENTS OF A COURT STORY



The following information should be carried in each court story:

1. The names, addresses and places of origin of all defendants (plus ages, if necessary). The precise address details will vary from one newspaper to another. For example, some newspapers like to give the address accurate to the house number in the street whereas others – perhaps national newspapers – may only name the town or village.
2. The offences they are charged with.
3. The plea of each defendant to each charge - guilty or not guilty.
4. The name of the court where the case is being heard.

In addition to the above, you should give the following information if possible:

1. The name of the judge or magistrate hearing the case. This is very much necessary, particularly while reporting the verdict or sentence.
2. The names of the prosecution and defence lawyers. You must also give the names and other details of all witnesses whose evidence you quote in your report.
3. The remaining report will be an account of the day's proceedings, quoting what was said by those who spoke - lawyers, the judge, and witnesses.

There are some differences in court reporting for newspaper, online, television and radio. Court reports for radio and television cannot be as long as court reports in newspapers and online platforms. Therefore television and radio give fewer details.

If a person is produced in a court through video conferencing, it would be better to write why this process was adopted.

Check Your Progress 3

Note: 1) Use the space given below for your answer.

2) Compare your answer with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. State the basic difference in court reporting for print and broadcast media.

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2. Discuss some of the essential elements for writing court stories.

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13.6 PRECAUTIONS NECESSARY IN LEGAL REPORTING

The most important precaution necessary for a court reporter is that s/he should not violate the provisions of Contempt of Courts Act 1971.

Contempt can be civil or criminal offence.

13.6.1 Civil Contempt

Civil contempt means wilful disobedience to any judgement, decree, direction, order or other process of a court, or willfully breach of an undertaking given by a person to a court. There will be no civil contempt where there is ignorance of the order of a court leading to unintentional breach.

13.6.2 Criminal Contempt

Criminal contempt mainly means publication of any matter, or the doing of any other act, which (i) scandalises or lowers the authority of any court; or (ii) prejudices or interferes with the due course of judicial proceedings.

13.6.3 Scandalising the Court

Under the law, publication of matter which creates doubts about the ability or fairness of a judge of a court is prohibited. A newspaper should not impute improper motives to a judge. In 1971, in the case of *Daphtary vs. Gupta*, the Supreme Court decided that to express an opinion that a judge “toes the line” of another is contempt. Similarly, the expression that a judge pronounces his judgement under the influence of liquor or lure of wealth is also contempt.

13.6.4 Trial by Media

In his article ‘Media: An International Perspective’ published in *The Practical Lawyer* Justice R.S. Chauhan has said, “Pre-trial publicity is injurious to the health of a fair trial. Even before the accused is arrested and

tried, the cacophony of media proclaims the accused to be guilty. It may project irrelevant and inadmissible evidence as the gospel truth, thereby convincing the people about the guilt of the accused. It, thus, undermines the fundamental principle of common law that every man is presumed to be innocent till proven guilty.”

Court reporting prejudicing fair trial may be of various forms. It is contempt (i) if a newspaper report deters a person from giving witness in a court; (ii) if the report offers threats or is written in abusive language compelling a party to discontinue the court proceedings; and (iii) if the report discusses the merits of a case pending in court.

In the USA, in the famous Sheppard Case (1966) the judgement pronounced by a court was reversed 12 years later on the ground of prejudicial publicity.

In the case of Sahara Real Estate Ltd vs. SEBI (Supreme Court judgement of September 2012), five-judge bench of the Supreme Court allowed the media to be partially restrained while reporting judicial proceedings by drawing a “Lakshman Rekha” for what it called balancing the freedom of expression and a fair trial. But the court refused to impose blanket restrictions saying guidelines on reporting cannot be framed across the board.

The court used the doctrine of “postponement of publication”, under which an aggrieved party can move a High Court or the Supreme Court seeking deferment of publication of sub-judice matter. After going through the content in question and the impact of its publication, the court can pass appropriate orders.

13.7 JOURNALISTIC DEFENCES

According to Sec. 5 of the Contempt of Courts Act, 1971 a person shall not be guilty of contempt of court for publishing any “fair comment” on the merits of any case which has been “heard and finally decided”.

Now two questions arise. What is “fair comment” and what is meant by “heard and finally decided?”

13.7.1 Fair Comments

There is no single formula to decide the fairness of a comment. The matter depends on the facts and circumstances of each case. To comment on the correctness of a judicial decision, whether on law or facts, is not contempt. Similarly, to point out inequality of sentences in two different cases of the same nature, is also not contempt. However, while commenting on the merits of a case if improper motives are imputed to the judge, then the comment ceases to be fair. Similarly, to express that the judgement was arbitrary or the judge was incompetent is also contempt.

13.7.2 Heard and Finally Decided

A fair comment on the merits of a case can be made when it is heard and finally decided. A case cannot be said to have been finally decided until the period of limitation for filing appeal has expired. Where an appeal or revision

has been filed, the comments on the merits of the case should not be published until the appeal is finally decided. P.M. Bakshi states in his book *Press Law* that in practice no one waits for the expiry of the limitation period.

13.7.3 Ignorance of Pendency

If a court story interferes with the course of justice, but its reporter had no reasonable ground to assume that the proceedings were pending, then one will not be guilty of contempt of court. Prior to the enactment of Contempt of Court Act, 1971, ignorance of pendency was not a defence or excuse.

13.7.4 Fair and Accurate Report

According to Section 4 of the Contempt of Court Act, 1971, fair and accurate report of the court proceedings is lawful. However, a report will be contemptuous if it has been prohibited by the court or is forbidden by any law.

13.7.5 Amendment of 2006 to Contempt of Courts Act, 1971

The 2006 amendment to the Act provides for truth as a valid defence in contempt proceedings.

In an article ‘Tensions between Natural Allies’ by V. Venkatesan, published in *The Hindu*, New Delhi of 26 June 2013, the writer’s observation is that the 2006 amendment has not really lead to any appreciable increase in reports critical of the judiciary. The reason perhaps is that this defence is available to the alleged contemner only at the sentencing stage, and the courts are free to find one guilty, irrespective of the amendment.

Venkatesan further states that Section 13 (b) of the Act – inserted by the amendment – gives wide discretion to the courts to admit truth as a defence to contempt proceedings if such a defence is in “public interest”, and the request for invoking the defence is “bona fide”.

13.7.6 Academic Writing

Academic writing or a report written academically on a point of law is not a contempt of court, just on the ground that the law discussed is at issue in a court.

13.8 PUNISHMENT

The maximum punishment for contempt of court is simple imprisonment of six months, or fine of two thousand rupees or both. If the accused apologises, the person may be discharged by the court without punishment. It is for the court to decide whether the apology is acceptable. Generally, an apology, to be acceptable by the court, should be sincere, unconditional and without delay. An apology should be made in a manner that substantially wipes out the mischief.

In the case of *L.D. Jaikwal vs. State of UP* (1984) the Supreme Court refused to accept an apology and the accused was sentenced for one week simple imprisonment.

In the suo moto contempt proceedings against the newspaper Marathwada, Bombay High Court, accepted the apology tendered by the paper.

In 2003, in a suo moto contempt case Full Bench of Punjab and Haryana High Court accepted the unconditional apology tendered by *The Tribune*, Chandigarh.

13.9 IN CAMERA PROCEEDINGS

Following are some statutes which prohibit publication of court proceedings or any part thereof :

- i) Section 228-A of the Indian Penal Code prohibits publication of identity of victims of certain sexual crimes.
- ii) Section 33 of the Special Marriage Act, 1954, and Section 22(1) of the Hindu Marriage Act, 1955, also provide for in camera proceedings.
- iii) In the interest of the security of the State, Section 14 of the Official Secrets Act, 1923, empowers the court to hold the proceedings of a case or any part thereof in camera.

Check Your Progress 4

Note: 1) Use the space given below for your answer
2) Compare your answer with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. What do you mean by 'heard and finally decided'?

.....

.....

.....

2. What do you mean by trial by media ?

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.....

.....

Activity

Read at least 10 articles or research papers based on 'Trial by Media' and write your views on it in the form of an article.

13.10 LET US SUM UP

Court reporting is increasing in India and also considered one of the important reporting beats. There is some difference in reporting for newspapers and broadcast media. Journalists cultivate the art of legal reporting by practice. If you want to be a good legal reporter, you should know the hierarchy of courts and meaning of important legal terms. You should have sufficient news sources. You should not get involved in trial by media, or violate the norms explained in the Contempt of Courts Act, 1971. You should also not give names of the victims of sexual offences. However,

in all circumstances, a court reporter's primary duty is to produce a copy which is interesting for his/her readers/viewers/listeners, and newsworthy too.

13.11 FURTHER READINGS

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13.12 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

1. Legal Reporting is synonymous with court reporting which covers court verdicts, judiciary conditions, national laws, proceedings of court cases and the legal trends.
2. That art is learned, cultivated and developed by spending time in courts watching cases, writing them up day after day and improving by practice.

Check Your Progress 2

1. In U.P., the Allahabad High Court has a bench in Lucknow. Bombay High Court has benches in Nagpur, Aurangabad and Panaji.
2. Live telecast of court proceedings will bring more transparency in judicial system.

Check Your Progress 3

1. Court reports for broadcast media cannot be as long as reports for newspapers.
2. 1. Names of defendants; 2. offences they are charged with; 3. plea of each defendant to each charge - guilty or not guilty; and 4.name of the court where the case is being heard.

Check Your Progress 4

1. A fair comment on the merits of a case can be made when it is heard and finally decided. A case cannot be said to have been finally decided until the period of limitation for filing appeal has expired.
2. It means publicizing irrelevant evidence as gospel truth, undermining the fundamental principle of common law that every man should be presumed to be innocent till proven guilty.

UNIT 14 POLITICAL REPORTING

Structure

- 14.0 Introduction
- 14.1 Learning Outcomes
- 14.2 Political System in India
- 14.3 Parliament and Political Reporting
- 14.4 Political Parties and Political Reporting
 - 14.4.1 Connecting with People (Rallies/Public Meetings/Roadshows)
 - 14.4.2 Protest (Processions/ Demonstrations)
 - 14.4.3 Press Briefings /Conferences
 - 14.4.4 Party Meetings/Conventions
 - 14.4.5 Press Release/Social Media Platform
- 14.5 Political Newsgathering and Writing
 - 14.5.1 Political Beat and its Coverage
 - 14.5.2 Sources in Political Reporting
 - 14.5.3 Political News Writing
- 14.6 Let Us Sum Up
- 14.7 Further Readings
- 14.8 Check Your Progress: Possible Answers

14.0 INTRODUCTION

This unit will delve into the diverse landscape of the Indian political system, exploring the intricate workings of political parties and the conduct of elections at different levels. Additionally, we will examine essential skills required to excel as a political reporter, including the art of building contacts for newsgathering and writing in an informed manner to ensure comprehension by your readers/listeners/viewers.

14.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After reading this Unit, you will be able to:

- gain a comprehensive understanding of the fundamental concepts of the Indian political system, essential for effective political reporting;
- acquire knowledge in diverse aspects of political newsgathering, including techniques for collecting reliable information and develop sources; and
- hone skills in political news writing, enabling the development of compelling and informed content that effectively communicates complex political issues to readers/ listeners/viewers.

Activity 1

Read a political news report from a newspaper or an online news source that features a local political leader.

1. Identify the following details from the news report:
 - which political party does the politician belong to?
 - what statement has the politician made?
 - what is the issue that the politician has raised?
 - Has the politician issued a Press Release, addressed a Press Conference, or written on any Social Media platform?
2. Reflect on your findings and discuss with your peers to gain insights into the nuances of political news reporting and the portrayal of political leaders in the media.

Above mentioned exercise aimed at helping you grasp the concept of political reporting. However, to fully comprehend political reporting in its entirety, it is imperative to delve into the fundamentals of parliamentary democracy, the intricacies of the Indian political system, and the multifarious issues of governance. Thus, let us commence by exploring these essential elements in detail.

14.2 POLITICAL SYSTEM IN INDIA

In democratic systems, there are two main forms of political systems - Parliamentary Form (such as in Britain) and Presidential Form (such as in the US). The Indian Constitution mandates a parliamentary form of democracy, where the Parliament or Legislature holds a paramount status in the political system. This is because the Executive, comprising the Prime Minister and the Cabinet, is drawn from the Parliament or Parliamentarians, and is accountable to the Parliament. This contrasts with the presidential form of democracy, where the Executive, including the President and the Cabinet, is not necessarily chosen from the Parliament and is not as directly accountable to the Parliament.

In the Indian context, like in other democracies, the Parliament (as well as State Assemblies) fulfils the crucial role of law-making. The Government, led by the Ministers, initiates the drafting of Bills that are presented in Parliament. After obtaining parliamentary approval and presidential assent, these Bills transform into Acts. These legislations and policy formulations are instrumental in governing the country, guiding the functioning of the government.

14.3 PARLIAMENT AND POLITICAL REPORTING

As previously mentioned, the Parliament and state legislatures play a vital role in India's political system. There is a keen public interest in understanding how parliamentary business is conducted and laws are formulated to address public welfare concerns. Consequently, it is the

responsibility of newspapers, news websites and news channels to provide comprehensive coverage of the proceedings and activities within the Parliament during its working sessions.

The Constitution of India sets up a Parliament with two parts: the Lok Sabha (the House of the People) and the Rajya Sabha (the Council of States). The Lok Sabha has members who are elected directly by the people. It stays in session for up to five years from its first meeting unless it's dissolved earlier.

The Rajya Sabha seats are allocated to different States and Union Territories based roughly on their population. The representatives of each state are elected by members of their respective State Legislative Assemblies (Vidhan Sabhas) using a system called proportional representation with a single transferable vote.

When the parliament and state legislatures are in session, they become important sources of news. The public is interested in knowing about the laws being discussed and debated in the parliament. The government has a responsibility to announce major acts and activities that happen during the session. The debates that take place in the parliament, as well as any disruptions caused by clashes between members of the ruling and opposition parties, are also news-worthy and worth reporting.

There are reporters who specifically cover the happenings in the parliament, as parliamentary reporting has evolved as a separate field of journalism over the years. However, all political reporters are expected to keep track of what's going on inside the parliament. Sometimes, political news may come from outside the parliament even while it is in session. If political parties are unable to express their frustration within the House, they may do so outside, and this is crucial information for political reporters to cover.

14.4 POLITICAL PARTIES AND POLITICAL REPORTING

Political parties play a vital role in shaping the political landscape of a country, and their activities are closely monitored by the media. Political reporting is the practice of reporting on the activities of political parties and politicians, and the interaction between the two is critical to the functioning of a healthy democracy. In this note, we will explore the activities of political parties and their relationship with political reporting. Political scientists explain four major functions of political parties:

- a. selection of candidates,
- b. mobilization of voters,
- c. facilitation of governance,
- d. monitoring the opposing party when it is in power.

A political reporter is required not only to recognize these functions, but he/she must appreciate the activities that the political parties undertake while performing these functions. Political parties play an important role in any democratic society. While covering the activities of political parties, it's

important to keep in mind that these activities are not always well-defined in a democratic setup.

The ultimate objective of these activities is to attract media attention and reach out to the masses. Political parties are constantly seeking to get adequate media coverage, which can help them gain more visibility and influence public opinion. As a political reporter, your job is to stay informed about the activities of political parties and provide accurate and timely coverage that informs the public and promotes a better understanding of the democratic process. Now we shall discuss some major activities of political parties which are important in political reporting.

14.4.1 Connecting with People (Rallies/Public Meetings/Roadshows)

Political parties engage in a variety of activities to connect with voters and promote their agendas. Some of the most common activities include street/corner meetings, public meetings, roadshows, rallies, padyatra and Rath Yatras. Public meetings are often addressed by senior leaders from ruling or opposition parties and are the most effective way of connecting with people. These meetings provide valuable input for political reporters who cover them, as the speeches made by leaders can be used to write good news reports. During elections, street/corner meetings are also popular, as are rallies which are used to demonstrate the party's strength and canvass for support. Bike and cycle rallies are also common, as are road shows where senior leaders use vehicles to reach out to the public and influence them. The Rath Yatra is a unique form of mass contact in India, where political leaders travel in large vehicles and stop at different locations to address the people from an elevated platform. All these activities provide ample material for political reporters to cover and report on the political landscape.

14.4.2 Protest (Processions/Demonstrations)

Political parties in the opposition often use various forms of protest to express their dissatisfaction with government policies and actions. These can include demonstrations, processions, dharnas, road blockades, and strikes or bandhs. Protesters often use banners, posters, and slogans to highlight their demands and condemn their political opponents.

Sometimes, these protests can turn violent, as party workers may resort to vandalism or attack police forces. The police may also use force to control the situation, leading to clashes with protesters. Silent processions and effigy burning are other common forms of protest used by political parties.

In extreme cases where violence cannot be controlled, paramilitary forces or even the army may be deployed to restore order. For political reporters, any such situation is big news, especially if there are injuries or casualties involved. It's important for reporters to cover these events accurately and objectively, providing the public with a clear understanding of the political climate and the issues at hand.

14.4.3 Press Briefings /Conferences

All major political parties in India hold daily press briefings at their national headquarters in New Delhi, typically in the afternoon or evening. The purpose of these briefings is to update the media on the party's stance on current issues of importance or urgency. They are also used to level charges against political opponents and to defend the party if charges have been made against its leaders.

The briefings are conducted by the party's official spokespersons, and senior leaders may also address reporters on special occasions. Political reporters make it a point to attend these briefings regularly to stay up to date on the party's stance on various issues. In addition to these daily briefings, political parties may also organize press conferences to share major news or updates with reporters. Unlike briefings, the date, time, and venue of press conferences must be notified in advance to allow reporters to attend.

14.4.4 Party Meetings/ Conventions

Political parties hold various types of meetings at regular intervals. Closed-door meetings, executive or working committee meetings, and senior leader meetings are held behind closed doors, making it difficult for political reporters to cover them unless the party officially communicates the outcome. Occasionally, political parties hold joint meetings to form a joint front or enter an alliance. Opposition parties may also seek meetings with the President and Prime Minister to submit their representations on various issues.

Political parties also organize their annual conventions and periodic conferences, which political reporters may have full or limited access to. This access makes it easier for reporters to cover these conventions and conferences and access information.

14.4.5 Press Release/Social Media Platform

Political parties provide essential information to political reporters through their press releases. However, these press releases are not issued regularly. Besides, political parties utilize social media platforms to engage with the public. It is crucial for political reporters to monitor these posts since they may lead to important news stories. Additionally, political parties publish their respective newsletters, such as Kamal Sandesh for the BJP, Congress Sandesh for the Congress, etc. The content in these publications, including reports and articles, can be valuable news sources for political reporters.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space given below for your answer

2) Compare your answer with those given at the end of this Unit.

1) What are the major activities of political parties that make news?

.....

.....

- 2) What is the purpose of press briefings ?

14.5 POLITICAL NEWSGATHERING AND WRITING

Political news gathering and writing involve the collection, analysis, and presentation of information related to politics, government, and policymaking. It is an essential function of the media, as it plays a crucial role in keeping the public informed and engaged in the democratic process.

Political news gathering involves several steps, including identifying potential news stories, conducting interviews with key players, researching background information, and fact-checking. Journalists need to have a deep understanding of politics and policymaking to be able to navigate complex issues and identify stories of public interest.

Once the information has been collected, journalists need to analyse and interpret it to provide context and insight. This involves synthesizing information from various sources, identifying patterns and trends, and providing an analysis of the political and social implications of the news.

Writing political news requires a high level of skill and attention to detail. Journalists must be able to distil complex issues into concise and understandable language, while also maintaining accuracy and objectivity. They must also be able to write in a way that is engaging and relevant to their audience.

In addition to traditional forms of journalism, such as print and broadcast news, political news is increasingly being disseminated through digital media channels, including social media platforms and online news outlets. This has created new opportunities for journalists to reach wider audiences, but it has also created new challenges, such as the need to verify information in a rapidly changing and often unregulated environment.

In newspapers, the reporting network comprises reporting broadly at three levels: City, State Capital, and National Capital. Here, the city reporting, or local reporting is referred to reporting from the city from where the newspaper edition is published. It is substituted by metro reporting in the case of reporting from metropolitan cities (if the newspaper is published from a metropolitan area). Every newspaper (from whichever city it is published) has a reporting set up in the state capital and the national capital. This reporting set up is called bureau.

14.5.1 Political Beat and its Coverage

There are different beats distributed to reporters in the City Reporting Room, the State Bureau, and the National Bureau. However, political beat is common at all the three levels, though the range of coverage differs. A political reporter in the local reporting room covers political activities happening in that city; while a reporter in the State Bureau covers political activities having wider reach including affairs related to the State Government. A reporter in the National Bureau covers national and international level politics including affairs related to the Central Government.

Let us have a look what is covered by a political reporter in a city:

- **District and City level units of political parties:** meetings, programmes, and political activities on the street.
- **Politicians, MLAs, and MPs:** activities and statements of local politicians that includes politicians who would have been elected to the State Legislature and the Parliament.
- **Senior leaders and ministers:** visits of the city by state and national level leaders of political parties, ministers of State/Central Government, Chief Minister, Prime Minister, and President.

Political reporter posted in the State Bureau covers the following activities:

- **State Units of political parties:** meetings, programmes, and other political activities either in the state capital or across the state
- **State Legislature:** Sessions of Legislative Assembly/Council; activities of MLAs/ MLCs
- **State Government:** functioning of the State Government, Chief Minister, and Governor
- **Central Government Ministers:** visits of the State capital by the Prime Minister, other Ministers, and the President

Political reporter posted in the National Bureau covers the following activities:

- **National Units of political parties:** meetings, programmes, and other political activities either in the national capital or across the country
- **Parliament:** sessions of Lok Sabha/Rajya Sabha, and the activities of MPs inside or outside Parliament
- **Central Government:** functioning of the Central Government, Prime Minister, and the President
- **Centre-State relations:** issues between the Centre and the State, particularly related to governance and policy matters.
- **International relations:** visits of head of states or other senior leaders from foreign countries, and agreements or pacts signed by leaders of respective countries.

14.5.2 Sources in Political Reporting

Political reporters tend to engage in field reporting or spot coverage as part of their news gathering process. This involves reporting on legislative sessions, public meetings, political leader speeches, demonstrations and rallies, election campaigning and polling, vote counting and election results, conventions, and meetings of political parties. A key component of their job is conducting on-the-spot interviews with political leaders or gathering sound bites from them.

As a result, political reporters have a demanding schedule and often must be mobile and always connected. They rely heavily on official sources such as press releases and statements from political parties and their leaders. They make sure to attend press briefings and conferences held by political parties and leaders and are sometimes briefed on the outcome of party meetings. When political controversies arise, reporters wait for the official party version.

However, political reporters cannot gain a competitive edge unless they develop confidential sources. These sources are usually insiders who provide vital information to reporters, including dissenting leaders or political opponents. Establishing and maintaining mutual trust between a political reporter and their source is crucial. Political reporters must cultivate confidential sources and be willing to protect their identity.

14.5.3 Political News Writing

In political news writing, the same inverted pyramid news structure is adopted which you would have already gone through. Here, the most important information or fact comes first, followed by the less important information, continued by some extra information, and followed by the least important facts. In writing lead of political news reports, the same 5 Ws and I H formula is applied.

Writing Speeches/Press Conferences/Interviews: A political reporter is mostly found writing stories on speeches, press conferences or briefings and interviews. These news stories have a common element; they are one-source stories. Such stories are collection of direct and indirect quotations from the source.

Speeches assume more significance if made by prominent political leaders and government functionaries. A reporter requires considerable skill to report a 4000- word speech in 300 words, and still give the reader an accurate report of what was said. The task becomes further difficult in the case of lengthy speeches.

All speeches, whether formal addresses on special occasions or impromptu remarks during an unstructured gathering, are handled very much alike. The reporter must consider the following three elements: - *the speaker, the audience and the speech*

A fourth consideration is the possible interpretation that any of the three elements may need. The proportion of the story to be devoted to each element varies with the comparative importance of each, but no story is complete without all three. While writing a political report, we should keep following things in our mind :

- i. **The speaker should be properly identified in the lead.** Sometime this can be done with a title or a short sentence. The reader needs to know who the speaker is and why his or her statements are worth quoting. Even a description of the speaker's distinctive characteristics and manner of emphasizing certain points is sometimes woven into the story to give it more colour.
- ii. **The audience should also be described.** How many people were there? Who were they? Why did they meet? The reporter needs to answer these questions in the news report. The names of persons in the audience need not be given unless it would be of interest to the reader to know the names of a few of the more prominent ones; but the reporter should tell whether they are bankers, teachers, doctors, engineers, farmers, or party workers. Audience reaction is also worth noting.
- iii. **The speech is the most important.** What was the most important thing said by the speaker should be the first question that a reporter should ask himself while sitting down to write the story. However, two reporters, covering the same speech may not agree on what was the most important thing said. That is why the news reports on the same speech is published with different emphasis in different newspapers/news websites.

In press conferences and interviews, only two elements, the speaker and the speech are considered important. Mostly, a political reporter writes the story in his/her own language and expression while taking care that the meaning of the statements made by the speaker does not change. Wherever required, the reporter decides to keep the statements in quotes. Though direct quotations tend to add emphasis, the reporter should avoid quoting routine, obvious or minor points from the speech or statements made by the speaker.

Meetings and special events: News stories based on meetings, conferences, conventions, and other political events form a major chunk of political reporting. There are so many meetings held by political parties every other day, but all of them are not worth reporting. There is no news value in the simple fact that a meeting or event has happened. A reporter should cover and write a story only when s/he is certain that the readers are interested in knowing about that meeting.

While writing a news report based on a meeting or an event, the reporter must provide answers to readers on the following questions:

Who attended the meeting? Whether prominent leaders of the party showed up or not?

What was the outcome of the meeting? Whether the decisions taken in the meeting will make some impact or not?

Types of Meeting Stories:

By now you would have understood that merely writing a news report based on a political meeting is not enough. A political reporter should also investigate two more aspects of a meeting report i.e., *Advance* and *Follow up*.

Most political parties rely on newspapers/TV channels/News websites for publicizing their meetings through a news report published/showed in advance. The information required for writing such a news story includes the name of the party (if it is breakaway faction), the agenda of the meeting, names of leaders addressing or attending the meeting, time, date, and place of the meeting. The more the reporter knows about the party and its leaders and the recent developments, the easier it will be for him to write an informative and interesting advance story.

The job of a political reporter does not finish after a meeting would have taken place and it has been reported in news media. The reporter must keep a track on the developments, if any, after the details/outcome/decisions of the meeting have been made public through news reports. The outcome of a meeting might be having far reaching consequences, and hence, a political reporter should always be vigilant on this count.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space given below for your answer

2) Compare your answer with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. Name the major activities covered by the political reporters posted in the State Bureau.

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2. Explain the types of meeting stories.

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14.6 LET US SUM UP

Political news is a crucial component of journalism, and a proficient political reporter must possess a comprehensive understanding of the country's constitution and political system. In this unit, we have provided a brief overview of India's political system as it holds great significance for political reporting. Furthermore, we have delved into the intricacies of political news gathering and writing to provide a comprehensive understanding of these crucial components of political journalism.

14.7 FURTHER READINGS

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14.8 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

1. The major activities of political parties that make news are following:

- i. Connecting with People (Rallies/Public Meetings/Roadshows)
- ii. Protest (Processions/ Demonstrations)
- iii. Press Briefings /Conferences
- iv. PartyMeetings/ Conventions
- v. Press Release/Social Media Platform

2. All major political parties in India hold regular press briefings at their national headquarters typically in the afternoon or evening. The purpose of these briefings is to update the media on the party's stance on current issues of importance or urgency. They are also used to level charges against political opponents and to defend the party if charges have been made against its leaders. The briefings are conducted by the party's official spokespersons, and senior leaders may also address reporters on special occasions. Political reporters make it a point to attend these briefings regularly to stay up to date on the party's stance on various issues.

Check Your Progress 2

1. A political reporter posted in the State Bureau covers the following activities:

State Units of political parties: meetings, programmes, and other political activities either in the state capital or across the state

State Legislature: Sessions of Legislative Assembly/Council; activities of MLAs/ MLCs

State Government: functioning of the State Government, Chief Minister, and Governor

Central Government Ministers: visits of the State capital by the Prime Minister, other Ministers, and the President

2. Meeting stories can be classified into two categories – advance story and follow up story.

Advance story: Most political parties rely on newspapers/TV channels/News websites for publicizing their meetings through a news report published/showed in advance. The information required for writing such a news story includes the name of the party (if it is breakaway faction), the agenda of the meeting, names of leaders addressing or attending the meeting, time, date, and place of the meeting. The more the reporter knows about the party and its leaders and the recent developments, the easier it will be for him to write an informative and interesting advance story.

Follow up story: The job of a political reporter does not finish after a meeting would have taken place and it has been reported in news media. The reporter must keep a track on the developments, if any, after the details/outcome/decisions of the meeting have been made public through news reports. The outcome of a meeting might be having far reaching consequences, and hence, a political reporter should always be vigilant on this count.



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